

Learn Canva

Complete Step-by-Step Guide for Students

Desktop Publishing (DTP) Course

For Beginners | Ages 10+ | No Experience Needed

Works on Windows 7 & Windows 10

No Installation Required | Works in Chrome & Firefox | Free to Use

14 Chapters | Step-by-Step Instructions | 5 Practice Projects

Notes | Use Cases | Examples | Do's & Don'ts

canva.com

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What is Canva?

WHAT IS IT?

Canva is a FREE online design tool. Make beautiful posters, birthday cards, flyers, and social media posts — right inside your web browser. No need to download or install any software!

WHY USE THIS?

Easy to use — even a 10-year-old can start on Day 1!

100% Free (basic version) — no credit card needed

Works in Chrome or Firefox browser — no software to install

100,000+ ready-made templates to choose from

No drawing or art experience required at all

All your designs are saved automatically to the cloud

What Can You Make in Canva?

Design Type	Example Use
Birthday Card	Custom card to surprise a friend!
School Poster	Science fair, notice board, project display
Visiting Card	Your own card with name, class and school
Festival Greeting	Diwali, Christmas, Eid wishes to share
Social Media Post	Instagram or Facebook posts
Simple Flyer	Advertise a school event or club
Presentation Slide	Class project presentation

NOTE

Canva works on Windows 7 and Windows 10 — just open Google Chrome or Firefox browser. You do NOT need to download or install anything!

USE CASE

Priya is in Class 6. She needs a science fair poster. Instead of drawing by hand, she opens Canva in Chrome, picks a free template, types her project details, adds pictures, and downloads as PDF — all in 20 minutes!

Getting Started — Create Your Account

WHAT IS IT?

Before designing, create a FREE Canva account. Takes less than 2 minutes!

What You Need Before Starting:

Item	Details
Computer	Windows 7 or Windows 10
Browser	Google Chrome (recommended) or Mozilla Firefox
Internet	WiFi or any internet connection
Email	Your school email or parent's email

Step-by-Step: Creating Your Canva Account

1	Open Your Browser Click the Chrome or Firefox icon on your Windows desktop.
2	Go to Canva Website In the address bar at the top type: www.canva.com then press Enter.
3	Click "Sign Up" You will see the Canva homepage. Click the big "Sign Up" button.
4	Choose Your Sign-Up Method Two easy options: Option A: Sign up with Google — Fastest! Recommended Option B: Sign up with Email and Password
5	Sign Up with Google (Recommended) Click "Continue with Google" . A Google login popup appears. Select your account and click Allow. Done — you are in!

6

Sign Up with Email

Click "**Sign up with email**".

Enter your name, email address, and a password.

Click "**Get started**".

Check your email for a confirmation link and click it.

7

You're In!

The Canva homepage opens. Congratulations — you are ready to design!

NOTE

Tip: Signing up with Google is the easiest — no password to remember! Always ask a parent or teacher to help you sign up for the first time.

EXAMPLE

Open Chrome → Type **canva.com** → Click **Sign Up** → Click **Continue with Google** → Select account → **Done!**

Canva Homepage Tour

WHAT IS IT?

After logging in you see the Canva Homepage. Let's learn what every part of the screen does so you can find everything easily!

Parts of the Canva Homepage:

Area	Location	What It Does
Canva Logo	Top left	Click to go back to the homepage
Search Bar	Top centre	Search for templates — type "birthday poster" etc.
"Create a Design"	Top right	Start a brand new design
Left Sidebar	Left side	Access Templates, Uploads, Projects and more
Recent Designs	Centre	Shows designs you have already made
Template Suggestions	Below centre	Popular templates to try quickly

Left Sidebar — What Each Option Does:

Option	What It Does
Home	Takes you back to the main Canva homepage
Templates	Browse 100,000+ ready-made design templates
Projects	All your saved designs appear here
Uploads	Upload your own photos and files from your computer
Apps	Extra tools and add-ons for Canva
Learn	Free video tutorials from Canva to help you improve

NOTE

When you first sign up, your Projects area will be empty — that is perfectly normal! You will fill it up as you create more and more designs.

USE CASE

Rahul wants a Diwali poster template. He types "Diwali poster" in the search bar and instantly sees hundreds of colourful free templates to choose from!

Creating Your First Design

WHAT IS IT?

Creating a new design means starting a fresh blank canvas where you can design anything you want from scratch or using a template!

Step-by-Step: Start a New Design

1	Click "Create a Design" Find the purple button in the top-right corner of the Canva homepage. Click it.
2	Choose a Design Type A dropdown list appears. Choose one: Presentation (16:9) — For slideshows Instagram Post — Square social media post A4 Document — Printing on regular paper Poster — Large posters for walls or boards Custom Size — You type in your own width and height
3	Search for a Specific Size In the search box inside the dropdown, type what you need — e.g. "A4", "business card".
4	The Design Editor Opens A blank white canvas appears. This is your creative playground!
5	Start Designing! Add templates, text, images, shapes and colours to your canvas.

Common Design Sizes — Quick Reference:

Design Type	Size	Best Used For
A4 Document	21 x 29.7 cm	School projects, notices, assignments
Poster	42 x 59.4 cm	Notice board, science fair display
Instagram Post	10.8 x 10.8 cm	Square social media posts
Business Card	8.9 x 5.1 cm	Personal visiting card
Presentation	25.4 x 14.3 cm	Class presentations

Facebook Post	12.6 x 6.6 cm	Facebook sharing
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NOTE

Not sure which size to pick? Choose **A4 Document** — perfect for school projects and prints on any regular home or school printer!

EXAMPLE

Mia wants a birthday card. She clicks "Create a Design", searches "birthday card", selects the card size — a blank canvas opens and she starts designing!

Working with Templates

WHAT IS IT?

A **Template** is a ready-made design — it already has colours, text, and pictures. You just change the words and images to make it YOUR own!

WHY USE THIS?

Templates save huge amounts of time! Start with something beautiful and personalise it in minutes. Canva has 100,000+ free templates!

Step-by-Step: Using a Template

- 1 Click "Templates" in Left Panel**
 On the left side of the design editor, click the Templates icon.
- 2 Browse or Search**
Option A: Scroll through to explore all templates.
Option B: Type a keyword — "birthday", "school poster", "science fair"
- 3 Hover to Preview**
 Move your mouse over any template to see a bigger preview of it.
- 4 Click to Use It**
 Click on the template. If it has multiple pages, Canva will ask: add all pages or one?
- 5 Edit the Text**
 Click on any text in the template and type your own words to replace it.
- 6 Change Colours**
 Click any coloured shape or element, then click the colour box in the toolbar.
- 7 Replace Images**
 Click any image in the template, then click "Replace" to swap it with your photo.
- 8 Design Ready!**
 You have personalised the template and made it your own! Download or share it.

NOTE

Free vs. Pro Templates: Templates with a small **crown icon** need Canva Pro (paid). Templates WITHOUT a crown are completely FREE. Thousands of beautiful free templates — always use those!

USE CASE

Ananya needs a birthday invitation for her friend. She searches "birthday invitation", picks a colourful free template, changes the name, date and time, and downloads. Done in 5 minutes!

EXAMPLE

Click Templates → Search "Diwali Poster" → Click a FREE template → Change the title text → Change one colour → Your poster is ready!

Text Tool — Adding Words to Your Design

WHAT IS IT?

The **Text Tool** lets you add words, headings, and titles to your design. Every good design needs clear text to tell people what it is about!

WHY USE THIS?

Text tells people what your design is about. A poster without words is just a picture! Good, readable text makes your design informative and beautiful.

Step-by-Step: Adding and Editing Text

- 1 Click "Text" in Left Panel**
 The Text panel opens on the left side of the editor.
- 2 Choose Text Type**
 Click one of the three options:
"Add a heading" — Big bold title text (largest size)
"Add a subheading" — Medium-sized text
"Add body text" — Small text for details and descriptions
- 3 Type Your Text**
 The text box appears on canvas, already selected. Just start typing!
- 4 Change the Font (Letter Style)**
 Click the text box to select it.
 In the **TOP TOOLBAR**, click the font name (e.g. "Arial").
 A font list opens — click any font to try it!
- 5 Change Text Size**
 Click the number next to the font name (e.g. "36").
 Type a new number, or use the + and – buttons.
- 6 Change Text Colour**
 Highlight your text (click and drag to select).
 Click the coloured **"A"** icon in the top toolbar.
 Click any colour to apply it!

7	Bold, Italic, Underline Select your text, then in the toolbar click: B = Bold (thick strong letters) I = Italic (tilted letters) U = Underline (line under the letters)
8	Align Text Left = text starts from left Center = centred Right = aligns to right
9	Move the Text Box Click and hold the edge of the text box, then drag it to any position.

Font Size Guide:

Text Type	Recommended Size	Used For
Heading	40 to 72 pt	Main title of poster or card
Subheading	20 to 36 pt	Section titles, subtitles
Body Text	10 to 16 pt	Details, descriptions, information

NOTE

Golden Font Rule: Never use more than **2 different fonts** in one design — it looks messy. Use one for headings and another for body text.

USE CASE

Suresh makes a school notice. He adds "SPORTS DAY" in big bold white text (size 60). Below it, smaller black text shows the date, time, and venue. Clear and professional!

EXAMPLE

Click Text → "Add a heading" → Type "WELCOME" → Size 60 → Bold → Blue colour → Centre align → Done!

Elements & Shapes

WHAT IS IT?

Elements are **decorations** you add to your design — shapes, lines, stickers, illustrations, frames, and much more!

WHY USE THIS?

Elements make your design look beautiful, fun, and interesting. They fill empty spaces and add colour. A poster with stickers looks SO much more exciting!

Types of Elements in Canva:

Type	What It Is	Example Use
Shapes	Circles, squares, stars, triangles	Backgrounds, borders, dividers
Lines	Straight and decorative lines	Separating sections on a poster
Stickers	Fun colourful animated decorations	Stars, hearts, balloons on cards
Illustrations	Hand-drawn style clipart images	Characters, objects, scenes
Frames	Shapes to place photos inside	Photo inside a circle or star shape
Charts	Bar, pie, and other graph types	Data and numbers in presentations

Step-by-Step: Adding and Editing Elements

- 1 Click "Elements" in Left Panel**
 The elements panel opens with categories: Lines & Shapes, Stickers, etc.
- 2 Search for an Element**
 Type what you need in the search box: **"star"**, **"heart"**, **"flower"**, **"border"**, **"trophy"**
- 3 Click to Add**
 Click once on any element and it instantly appears on your canvas.

4	Resize Click the element to select it (white handles appear). Drag the white circles at the CORNERS to resize. Hold Shift while dragging to keep the original shape proportions.
5	Move Click and hold anywhere on the element, then drag it to any position.
6	Change Colour Click the element to select it. Click the coloured square in the top toolbar. Choose any colour!
7	Rotate Hover your cursor just BELOW the element. A curved arrow icon appears. Click and drag it left or right to rotate the element.
8	Delete Click the element to select it, then press the Delete or Backspace key.

NOTE

Free vs. Paid Elements: Elements with a small **crown icon** need Canva Pro. Elements **without the crown** are completely FREE — hundreds of amazing choices!

USE CASE

Divya searches "balloon" in elements, picks colourful balloon stickers, and places them around her birthday poster title. Adds a big star shape at the top. Looks amazing!

EXAMPLE

Click Elements → Search "heart" → Click a heart sticker → Drag it to the corner → Change colour to Red → Done!

Images & Photos

WHAT IS IT?

Add photos two ways: (1) Use **Canva's free photo library**, or (2) **Upload your own photo** from your computer.

WHY USE THIS?

Photos make your design come alive! The right image makes your poster, card, or flyer much more attractive and meaningful to readers.

Part A — Using Canva's Free Photo Library

- 1 Search for a Photo**
In the search bar type what you need — "mountains", "school children", "flowers".
- 2 Click the "Photos" Filter**
After searching, click the **"Photos"** tab to see only real photographs.
- 3 Click to Add**
Click once and the photo appears on canvas. Move and resize as needed.

Part B — Uploading Your Own Photo

- 1 Click "Uploads" in Left Panel**
The uploads panel opens in the left sidebar.
- 2 Click "Upload Files"**
A file picker window opens on your Windows computer.
- 3 Select Your Photo**
Navigate to Desktop or Pictures folder.
Click your photo file (JPG or PNG format).
Click **"Open"**.
- 4 Wait for Upload**
The photo uploads and appears as a thumbnail in a few seconds.

5	Click Photo to Add Click the thumbnail — the photo appears on your canvas.
6	Resize and Move Drag the corners to resize. Drag the centre to move.

Editing and Adjusting a Photo:

1	Click the Photo White handles appear around the selected photo.
2	Click "Edit image" in Toolbar An editing panel opens on the left.
3	Adjust Settings Brightness — Make lighter or darker Contrast — Make colours more distinct Saturation — More or less vivid colours Blur — Add a soft blur effect
4	Click "Apply" Your edits are saved.

NOTE

Safety Rule: Only upload photos that belong to YOU or your family. Never upload photos of others without permission. JPG and PNG are best formats.

USE CASE

Rohan makes a personal ID card for a school project. He uploads his own photo from his computer, adds it to the card, and resizes it to fit the frame perfectly!

Colors & Backgrounds

WHAT IS IT?

The **background** is the base layer of your entire design. Make it a solid colour, a gradient, or even a photo! The background sets the whole mood.

Step-by-Step: Changing Background Colour

- 1 Click on an Empty Area of the Canvas**
 Click somewhere with no text or element on it.
- 2 Click the Colour Box in Toolbar**
 A coloured square appears at the top left. Click it.
- 3 Choose a Colour**
Option A: Click a ready-made colour from the colour grid.
Option B: Click the "+" button to open the full colour picker.
Option C: Type a HEX code — e.g. **#FF5733** for an orange-red.
- 4 Background Changes Instantly!**
 Your canvas background immediately changes to your chosen colour.

Colour Meanings — Fun Guide:

Colour	Mood / Feeling	Best Used For
Red	Exciting, Urgent, Energetic	Sports, alerts, sale events
Blue	Calm, Trustworthy, Professional	School, science, technology
Yellow	Happy, Cheerful, Fun	Birthdays, festivals, children
Green	Nature, Health, Growth	Environment, food, health topics
Purple	Creative, Royal, Mysterious	Art, music, celebrations
Orange	Energetic, Friendly, Warm	Sports, food, fun events
Pink	Caring, Playful, Gentle	Birthdays, love, kids designs
White	Clean, Simple, Minimal	Backgrounds, modern clean designs

Adding a Photo as Background:

1	Search in Elements Type "background" or a theme — "space background", "floral background", "watercolour".
2	Click the Image It automatically fills your entire canvas as the background.
3	Adjust if Needed Double-click the background to reposition it. Drag edges to resize.

NOTE

Readability Rule: Light background + Dark text = Easy to read. Dark background + White text = Cool! NEVER use yellow text on white background — completely impossible to read!

USE CASE

Kavya makes a Holi festival poster. She picks a bright colourful abstract background from Elements and adds white text on top. The vivid colours match the festival mood!

EXAMPLE

Click empty canvas area → Click colour box → Pick Dark Blue → Add text in White colour → Beautiful and easy to read!

Layers & Arrangement

WHAT IS IT?

When you add multiple elements they **stack** on top of each other like sheets of paper. **Layers** control which item appears in front and which appears behind.

WHY USE THIS?

Sometimes a shape might cover your text, or a photo might hide a sticker. Knowing how to control layers lets you fix these problems in seconds!

Step-by-Step: Controlling Layers

- 1 Click the Element You Want to Move**
 White handles appear around the selected element.
- 2 Right-Click on It**
 A right-click menu appears with layer arrangement options.
- 3 Choose the Option You Need**
"Bring to Front" — Moves all the way to the top (in front of everything)
"Bring Forward" — Moves one step closer to the front
"Send Backward" — Moves one step further back
"Send to Back" — Moves all the way to the back (behind everything)

Layer Options — Quick Reference:

Option	Result	When to Use It
Bring to Front	Element appears on top of everything	Text is hidden behind an image
Bring Forward	Moves one step forward in the stack	Fine-tuning the element order
Send Backward	Moves one step back in the stack	Fine-tuning the element order
Send to Back	Goes behind everything else	Pushing a shape behind your text

NOTE

Can't click an element because another is on top? Right-click the area — Canva shows ALL overlapping elements in a list so you can select the right one.

USE CASE

Amit places a text box but it goes behind a colourful shape. He right-clicks, selects "**Bring to Front**" — the text appears perfectly on top!

Undo & Redo — Your Safety Net

WHAT IS IT?

Undo and **Redo** are your best friends in Canva! Made a mistake? No problem at all — just undo it instantly!

Undo — "Take Back My Last Action":

Method	How to Do It
Keyboard Shortcut (Fastest)	Press Ctrl + Z on your keyboard
Click the Button	Click the back arrow at the top-left of the Canva editor

Redo — "Bring Back What I Just Undid":

Method	How to Do It
Keyboard Shortcut (Fastest)	Press Ctrl + Y on your keyboard
Click the Button	Click the forward arrow at the top-left of the editor

Useful Keyboard Shortcuts to Remember:

Shortcut	What It Does
Ctrl + Z	Undo — take back your last action
Ctrl + Y	Redo — bring back what you undid
Ctrl + C	Copy a selected element
Ctrl + V	Paste the copied element
Ctrl + D	Duplicate — copy and paste in one step
Delete / Backspace	Delete the selected element
Ctrl + A	Select ALL elements on the canvas
Ctrl + Z (many times)	Keep undoing — go back many steps

NOTE

You can undo MANY times in a row! Keep pressing Ctrl+Z to go back step by step. **Don't be afraid to experiment** — you can always undo any mistake!

EXAMPLE

You accidentally delete your title text. Press **Ctrl + Z** and it comes back immediately! Press it multiple times to roll back many steps at once.

Saving & Downloading Your Design

WHAT IS IT?

Canva auto-saves your work every few seconds — you **never need to click Save!** When ready, download your design to print or share.

NOTE

Canva **Auto-Saves Everything!** Every change you make is saved instantly to the cloud. You will see **"Saved"** at the top. Even a power cut cannot lose your work!

Step-by-Step: Downloading Your Design

1	Click "Share" Purple button in the top-right corner of the design editor.
2	Click "Download" A menu appears. Click Download from the options.
3	Choose Your File Format A panel opens on the right. Select the format: PNG — Crisp sharp quality (recommended for most uses) JPG — Good for photos, smaller file size PDF Standard — Best format for home printing PDF Print — High quality for professional printing
4	Select Pages For multi-page designs, choose to download all pages or specific ones.
5	Click the "Download" Button Canva prepares your file. The download starts automatically.
6	Find Your File Your file is saved to the Downloads folder on your computer. To find it: Open File Explorer → Click "Downloads" on the left side.

Which File Format to Use:

What You Want to Do	Best Format
Print at home (school project, notice)	PDF Standard
Professional high-quality printing	PDF Print
Share on WhatsApp or social media	JPG
Sharp high-quality image file	PNG
Design with transparent background	PNG
Send to teacher by email	PDF Standard

Sharing Your Design via Link:

1	Click "Share" Top-right corner of the design editor.
2	Click "Copy link" Canva generates a shareable link to your design.
3	Send the Link Share via WhatsApp, email, or any messaging app. Anyone with the link can view it!

USE CASE

Meera finishes her science poster. She clicks Share → Download → PDF Standard → Download. File saves to Downloads folder. She checks it looks perfect, then takes it to school for printing. The teacher is impressed!

Practice Projects

Now practise what you learned! Complete these 5 fun projects to build your Canva skills from beginner to confident designer.

PROJECT 1: Birthday Invitation Card

What to Make: A colourful birthday invitation card for your friend

Design Size: Birthday Card / A5

- Step 1: Canva.com → Create a Design → Search "Birthday Card"
- Step 2: Pick a free colourful template (no crown icon)
- Step 3: Change the name to your friend's name
- Step 4: Update the date, time and venue
- Step 5: Add birthday stickers (Elements → search "balloon")
- Step 6: Change colours to your friend's favourite colours
- Step 7: Download as PDF Standard and print it!

Skills practised: Templates, Text editing, Elements, Downloading

PROJECT 2: School Notice Board Poster

What to Make: A notice poster for Sports Day or any school event

Design Size: Poster (A2 or A3)

- Step 1: Create a Design → Choose Poster size
- Step 2: Set a colourful background (blue or green works great)
- Step 3: Add heading: "SPORTS DAY!" — big, bold, white text
- Step 4: Add details below — Date, Time, and Venue in smaller text
- Step 5: Search Elements for sports icons (football, trophy, medal)
- Step 6: Add a decorative border using Lines & Shapes elements
- Step 7: Download as PDF Print for the best printing quality

PROJECT 3: Personal Visiting Card

What to Make: Your own visiting card with your name and details

Design Size: Business Card (8.9 x 5.1 cm)

- Step 1: Create a Design → Search "Business Card"
- Step 2: Pick a clean professional free template
- Step 3: Replace the name text with YOUR name (big bold text)
- Step 4: Add your class name and school name
- Step 5: Upload your own photo and add it to the card
- Step 6: Change colours to ones you like
- Step 7: Download as PDF Print

Skills practised: Templates, Text, Photo upload, Small design sizes

PROJECT 4: Festival Greeting Post

What to Make: A Diwali/Christmas/Eid greeting to share on WhatsApp

Design Size: Instagram Post (1080 x 1080 px)

- Step 1: Search "Diwali greeting" or "Christmas card" in Templates
- Step 2: Pick a colourful free template
- Step 3: Change the greeting text to your custom message
- Step 4: Add your name at the bottom — e.g. "From: Riya"
- Step 5: Add festival stickers — diyas, candles, stars, lights
- Step 6: Download as JPG to share easily on WhatsApp

Skills practised: Template search, Text editing, Stickers, JPG download

PROJECT 5: School Club Flyer (Blank Canvas Challenge!)

What to Make: A flyer for a school club or event — designed from SCRATCH!

Design Size: A4 Document

Step 1: Create a Design → A4 Document size

Step 2: Start from a BLANK canvas — no template this time!

Step 3: Add a colourful background colour

Step 4: Add a large heading — club name or event title

Step 5: Add details — what, when, where, who can join

Step 6: Search and add a relevant photo from Canva library

Step 7: Decorate with shapes and stickers

Step 8: Download as PDF Standard

Skills practised: ALL tools combined — the ultimate blank canvas challenge!

Do's and Don'ts — Important Tips

Follow these rules to always create great designs and stay safe online!

DO'S

Always use FREE templates and elements (no crown icon)

Check "Saved" appears at the top after making changes

Use 2 to 3 matching colours that go well together

Keep text big enough to read easily (at least size 12 pt)

Ask a parent or teacher before signing up for the first time

Press Ctrl+Z whenever you make any mistake

Download as PDF Standard for the best print quality

Experiment freely — Canva has undo, so nothing is permanent!

DON'TS

Don't use Pro (crown) templates — use FREE ones only

Don't upload photos of other people without their permission

Don't use more than 2 different fonts in one design

Don't make text too small — always keep it easy to read

Don't use too many colours — 2 to 3 colours is more than enough

Don't put light coloured text on a light background (hard to read!)

Don't share your Canva account login with anyone else

Don't overcrowd your design — white/empty space looks great!

TIP

The best way to learn Canva is to **PRACTICE**! Open Canva today and try Project 1 from Chapter 13. The more designs you create, the better and faster you will get. Have fun — and enjoy creating amazing things!

You have completed the Canva Course!

Keep Designing. Keep Creating. Keep Learning.

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